ACADEMIC CENTRAL

PRACTICE EXAMINATION

GRADE 8

ENGLISH FIRST ADDITIONAL LANGUAGE

PAPER 2 · LITERATURE

MARKS: 60 **TIME: 2 hours**

Section A: Short story (25) · Section B: Poetry (20) · Section C: Drama (15). The texts are new to learners (unseen) and were written by Academic Central, so learners practise the literary skills used with any set work: narrator, setting, character, conflict, irony, symbolism, theme, imagery, figures of speech, rhyme, tone and stage directions.

Written by Academic Central for practice, following the CAPS curriculum for Grade 8. It is not a Department of Basic Education examination paper.

INSTRUCTIONS AND INFORMATION

1. This question paper consists of THREE sections: SECTION A: Short story (25 marks), SECTION B: Poetry (20 marks) and SECTION C: Drama (15 marks).
2. Answer ALL the questions.
3. Read each text carefully before you answer the questions on it.
4. Number your answers exactly as the questions are numbered.
5. Answer in full sentences unless you are told otherwise. Use your own words where you are asked to explain.

SECTION A: SHORT STORY

QUESTION 1

Read the short story and answer the questions that follow.

The Green Gate

Everyone in Zone 4 knew about the green gate. Behind it lived Mr Nkosi, the angriest man in Mamelodi – or so we believed. If your ball went over his wall, it was gone for ever. My cousin Sello said Mr Nkosi kept a whole room full of our balls and counted them at night like a dragon counting gold.

I was twelve that summer, and I had just been given my first real leather ball for my birthday. On the third day, Sello kicked it so hard that it sailed over the wall and landed with a soft thud on the other side.

"Well," said Sello, backing away, "that's the end of that."

I stared at the green gate. Then, before I could change my mind, I pushed it open.

The yard was not what I expected. There were no piles of stolen balls, only rows and rows of vegetables: spinach, beans, tomatoes on wooden sticks, and pumpkins as big as car tyres. And in the middle of it all, lying face down between the beans, was Mr Nkosi.

For a moment I could not move. Then I ran to him. His breathing was slow and rough. I shouted for Sello, and Sello, for once in his life, did exactly what he was told: he ran to call my mother, who called an ambulance.

Mr Nkosi spent two weeks in hospital. While he was away, somebody had to water the garden, and somehow that somebody became me. Every afternoon I filled the buckets at the tap, and every afternoon I noticed something new: the neat labels on each row, the small bench under the peach tree, the old exercise book on the windowsill with names and dates written inside it.

When Mr Nkosi came home, he was thinner, and he walked with a stick. He looked at the wet soil and then at me for a long time.

"You watered my beans," he said. It was not a question.

"Yes, sir."

He nodded slowly and went inside. I thought that was the end of it. But the next morning there was a box outside our door. Inside were twelve soccer balls, faded and scratched – and on top, my new leather ball, still shiny. A note in shaky handwriting said: *I kept them because children were trampling my seedlings. The vegetables go to the children's home on Tsamaya Road. I could use some help. – S. Nkosi.*

That afternoon, Sello and I knocked on the green gate. This time, it was already open.

1.1 Who is the narrator of the story? (1)

1.2 Where does the story take place? (1)

1.3 Give TWO things the children believed about Mr Nkosi at the beginning of the story. (2)

1.4 "… counted them at night like a dragon counting gold." Name the figure of speech and explain what it shows about how the children saw Mr Nkosi. (3)

1.5 Why was losing this ball especially upsetting for the narrator? (1)

1.6 "The yard was not what I expected." What did the narrator expect to find, and what did he or she actually find? (2)

1.7 "Sello, for once in his life, did exactly what he was told." What does this suggest about Sello? (1)

1.8 What does the narrator's decision to water the garden reveal about his or her character? Explain. (2)

1.9 Name TWO things the narrator noticed in the garden which show that Mr Nkosi is careful and organised. (2)

1.10 "'You watered my beans,' he said. It was not a question." Explain what the narrator means. (1)

1.11 According to his note, why had Mr Nkosi kept the balls? (1)

1.12 Explain the irony in this story. (2)

1.13 At the end, the green gate "was already open". What does the open gate symbolise? (2)

1.14 How does the narrator's attitude towards Mr Nkosi change during the story? (2)

1.15 What is the main theme (message) of the story? (2)

[25]

SECTION B: POETRY

QUESTION 2

Read the two poems and answer the questions on BOTH poems.

POEM 1: Taxi Rank at Dawn

The rank wakes before the sun,
yawning in exhaust and diesel,
hooters arguing like old friends.

Gogo sells vetkoek from a plastic tub,
steam rising like morning prayers;
a boy in an oversized blazer
counts coins into his palm, twice.

Destinations are shouted, not written:
"Bree! Bree! Joburg! Joburg!"
And the city, hungry as always,
swallows us one taxi at a time.

2.1 At what time of day is the poem set? Quote a line to support your answer. (2)

2.2 "The rank wakes … / yawning in exhaust and diesel" (lines 1–2). Name the figure of speech and explain what it suggests about the taxi rank. (2)

2.3 "hooters arguing like old friends" (line 3). What does this simile tell us about the sound at the rank? (2)

2.4 Why do you think the boy counts his coins "twice" (line 7)? (2)

2.5 What is the effect of the repetition in line 9? (1)

2.6 "And the city, hungry as always, / swallows us one taxi at a time" (lines 10–11). Explain what the poet means. (2)

POEM 2: Report Card

My report came home in a long brown file,
Mama read it slowly, without a smile;
Maths was a "four" and English a "three",
The teacher wrote, "She can do better – you'll see."

That night I sat at the kitchen table
And worked as hard as I was able;
While others slept, I fought each sum
Until my weary hand felt numb.

The year has turned, the file came back,
With marks that showed I'd found my track;
She clapped and laughed, her voice rang high –
My Mama's smile could touch the sky.

2.7 Write down the rhyme scheme of stanza 1. (2)

2.8 How did Mama feel when she first read the report? Quote a phrase to support your answer. (2)

2.9 "I fought each sum" (line 7). Name the figure of speech and explain its meaning. (2)

2.10 "My Mama's smile could touch the sky" (line 12). Name the figure of speech and explain what it tells us about Mama. (2)

2.11 In ONE sentence, state the message of Poem 2. (1)

[20]

SECTION C: DRAMA

QUESTION 3

Read the drama scene and answer the questions that follow.

The Election

Characters: NALEDI (14), a candidate for class representative · TUMI (14), the other candidate · KAGISO (14), Naledi's friend · MS DLAMINI, the class teacher
Setting: A Grade 8 classroom during break, the day before the class election.

(NALEDI is pinning a poster to the notice board: "VOTE NALEDI – A VOICE FOR EVERYONE". KAGISO rushes in, holding up his phone.)

KAGISO: *(out of breath)* Naledi, have you seen the class group chat?

NALEDI: *(still pinning)* I've been busy. Why?

KAGISO: Someone posted that you copied your science project from the internet. Everyone is sharing it.

NALEDI: *(turning sharply)* That's a lie! I worked on that project for three weeks.

KAGISO: I know. But the message came from Tumi's number.

(TUMI enters, eating an apple. She stops when she sees them.)

TUMI: *(sweetly)* Oh, hi. Nice poster. Very … colourful.

NALEDI: *(holding up Kagiso's phone)* Did you post this?

TUMI: *(shrugging)* I only shared what I heard. It's a free country.

NALEDI: *(her voice shaking)* You know it isn't true.

TUMI: *(smiling)* Do I? Anyway, people will believe what they want to believe.

(MS DLAMINI appears in the doorway. Nobody notices her.)

NALEDI: *(taking a deep breath)* Fine. Tomorrow I'll bring every page of my research notes. Anyone who wants to can read them. I don't need to tell lies to win.

TUMI: *(laughing)* Nobody reads notes, Naledi.

MS DLAMINI: *(stepping forward)* I do.

(TUMI drops her apple. Silence.)

MS DLAMINI: *(calmly)* Tumi, please come and see me after school. And bring your phone.

(TUMI exits slowly. KAGISO grins at NALEDI, who looks at her poster and straightens it.)

NALEDI: *(quietly)* A voice for everyone. Even when it's hard.

(Lights fade.)

3.1 Where and when does this scene take place? (2)

3.2 What is the main conflict in this scene? (2)

3.3 Tumi speaks "(sweetly)". What does this stage direction, together with her words, suggest about her real attitude towards Naledi? (2)

3.4 Quote ONE line which shows that Tumi does not care whether the message is true. (1)

3.5 How does Naledi plan to prove that she did not copy her project? (1)

3.6 Explain why the stage direction "Nobody notices her" is important for the audience. (2)

3.7 Why does Tumi drop her apple? (1)

3.8 Naledi's last line repeats her election slogan. What does it show about her? (2)

3.9 What lesson does this scene teach about the use of social media? (2)

[15]

TOTAL: 60

END OF QUESTION PAPER